

Psalms 97

Clouds and Darkness Are Round About Him

Clouds and darkness are round about him: righteousness and judgment are the habitation of his throne
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The LORD reigneth; let the earth rejoice; let the multitude of isles be glad thereof.*
- 2 *Clouds and darkness are round about him: righteousness and judgment are the habitation of his throne.*
- 3 *A fire goeth before him, and burneth up his enemies round about.*
- 4 *His lightnings enlightened the world: the earth saw, and trembled.*
- 5 *The hills melted like wax at the presence of the LORD, at the presence of the Lord of the whole earth.*
- 6 *The heavens declare his righteousness, and all the people see his glory.*
- 7 *Confounded be all they that serve graven images, that boast themselves of idols: worship him, all ye gods.*
- 8 *Zion heard, and was glad; and the daughters of Judah rejoiced because of thy judgments, O LORD.*
- 9 *For thou, LORD, art high above all the earth: thou art exalted far above all gods.*
- 10 *Ye that love the LORD, hate evil: he preserveth the souls of his saints; he delivereth them out of the hand of the wicked.*
- 11 *Light is sown for the righteous, and gladness for the upright in heart.*
- 12 *Rejoice in the LORD, ye righteous; and give thanks at the remembrance of his holiness.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 97 pictures God's reign in storm imagery—fire, lightning, trembling earth, melting hills—deliberately unsettling any comfortable, tame notion of His kingship, while simultaneously grounding that same throne in righteousness and judgment rather than mere raw power. Henry notes the pairing is intentional: the mystery and awe of God's presence (clouds and darkness) never operates apart from moral order (righteousness and judgment), and idol-worshippers are shown to have nothing but shame waiting for them when this King is finally seen clearly.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The Lord's reign is announced as cause for the earth's rejoicing and even the gladness of many isles. Yet His presence is deliberately mysterious—clouds and darkness surround Him—while His throne's actual foundation is named plainly: righteousness and judgment. Fire goes before Him, burning up His enemies on every side.

Verse 4-6

Cosmic upheaval attends this reign: lightnings light the world, the earth sees and trembles, hills melt like wax at the presence of the Lord of the whole earth. The heavens themselves declare His righteousness, and all people see His glory—creation itself testifies before any human voice does.

Verse 7-9

A direct word to idolaters: let all who worship images be put to shame, all who boast in worthless idols; worship Him instead, all you gods. Zion hears and is glad, the towns of Judah rejoice, because of God's judgments—His righteous rule is received as good news by His own people even as it shames every rival claim to worship.

Verse 10-12

The closing appeal turns practical: love the Lord, hate evil, since He preserves the souls of His saints and delivers them from the hand of the wicked. Light is sown for the righteous, gladness for the upright in heart; the fitting response is to rejoice in the Lord and give thanks at the remembrance of His holiness.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God's presence is genuinely mysterious and unsettling—clouds, darkness, fire, trembling earth—yet that mystery is never separated from moral order; His throne's actual foundation is righteousness and judgment, not raw, arbitrary power. Every rival object of worship is shown to be worthless before this King, while those who actually love Him and hate evil are promised preservation and sown light.

Application for life today.

Resist reducing God to either pure mystery detached from morality or pure moral order detached from awe; this psalm insists on both together—hold reverence and ethical seriousness in the same breath. Examine what modern equivalents of 'graven images'—things you quietly trust or boast in instead of God—need to be named and set aside (v. 7). Let verse 10's simple pairing, love the Lord and hate evil, function as a daily examination rather than an abstract ideal.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where have you separated awe of God's mystery from serious moral response, holding one without the other, when this psalm insists on both (vv. 1–2)?

2. What present-day 'graven image'—a source of trust or boasting other than God—does verse 7 call you to name honestly and let go of?

3. How does the simple pairing 'love the Lord, hate evil' (v. 10) function as a practical daily check, rather than just a poetic phrase, in your life right now?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).